

What Is the Scroll?

Understanding the Scroll of Revelation 5

Introduction

Few images in the book of Revelation are more mysterious—or more important—than the scroll John sees in the right hand of the One seated upon the throne:

“And I saw in the right hand of Him who sat on the throne a scroll written inside and on the back, sealed with seven seals.”¹

— Revelation 5:1

John does not immediately tell us what the scroll contains. Instead, he describes its appearance, its seven seals, the inability of anyone in heaven or on earth to open it, and the dramatic moment when the Lamb takes it from the hand of God. Only then does heaven erupt in worship.

The natural question is therefore: *What is the scroll?*

Several interpretations have been proposed. Some have identified it as the title deed to the earth; others have understood it as a book of judgment, God's prophetic program for the end of the age, or even the record of His purposes for creation.

The safest conclusion is not to force the scroll into one narrow category. Revelation itself does not call it a “title deed,” nor does it explicitly say that it is simply a book containing the seven judgments. Rather, when Revelation 5 is read in light of its Old Testament background, a broader and more compelling picture emerges.

The scroll of Revelation 5 may be best understood as the sealed heavenly decree of God's sovereign purposes for the consummation of His plan for creation—the divine document associated with judgment, redemption, inheritance, and the establishment of Christ's kingdom.

¹ Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).

I. The Scroll Written on Both Sides

The first clue is the unusual description of the scroll. John sees a document “written inside and on the back.” This detail immediately recalls the prophet Ezekiel.

Ezekiel describes his own vision:

“Then I looked and saw a hand reaching out to me, and in it was a scroll, which He unrolled before me. And written on the front and back of it were words of lamentation, mourning, and woe.”

— Ezekiel 2:9–10

The parallel is striking. Both prophets see a heavenly scroll written on both sides, and in both cases the scroll is associated with divine judgment.

The similarity strongly suggests that John's description is intended to evoke Ezekiel's vision. The fact that both sides are written upon also appears to communicate fullness. God's message is complete; nothing remains to be added.

Ezekiel's scroll contains “lamentation, mourning, and woe,” while the opening of John's scroll leads into judgments that ultimately culminate in the defeat of evil and the establishment of God's kingdom.

The Ezekiel parallel therefore provides strong evidence that the Revelation scroll contains a complete divine pronouncement concerning judgment and the fulfillment of God's purposes.

II. The Scroll and Daniel's Sealed Revelation

A second major background is found in the book of Daniel.

Daniel receives revelations concerning the end of the age, including resurrection, judgment, the deliverance of God's people, and the triumph of God's kingdom. At the conclusion of those revelations, he is told:

“But you, Daniel, shut up these words and seal the book until the time of the end. Many will roam to and fro, and knowledge will increase.”

— Daniel 12:4

Later, Daniel is told:

“Go on your way, Daniel, for the words are closed up and sealed until the time of the end.”

— Daniel 12:9

Revelation 5 presents a strikingly similar situation. John sees a heavenly scroll sealed with seven seals and hears the question:

“Who is worthy to break the seals and open the scroll?”

— Revelation 5:2

No one is found worthy, and John begins to weep.

Then one of the elders tells him:

“Do not weep! Behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has triumphed to open the scroll and its seven seals.”

— Revelation 5:5

Daniel's sealed revelation and John's sealed scroll are not necessarily the same document. Nevertheless, the connection is significant.

Both concern God's purposes for the end of the age, and both are associated with something sealed until the appointed time.

Revelation presents Christ as the One who possesses the authority to open what had been sealed and bring God's purposes toward their appointed completion.

III. The Jeremiah Connection: A Sealed Deed of Redemption and Restoration

Jeremiah 32 provides another important background because it contains a sealed legal document associated with redemption, inheritance, and restoration.

During the Babylonian siege of Jerusalem, God commanded Jeremiah to purchase a field from his relative Hanamel. Jeremiah records:

“So I bought the field in Anathoth from my cousin Hanamel, and I weighed out seventeen shekels of silver. I signed and sealed the deed, called in witnesses, and weighed out the silver on the scales.”

— Jeremiah 32:9–10

The reason for this unusual transaction becomes clear when God declares:

“Houses, fields, and vineyards will again be bought in this land.”

— Jeremiah 32:15

The sealed deed therefore represented a legally established promise of future restoration even though Jerusalem was about to experience judgment.

This provides an important background for the familiar description of the Revelation scroll as the “title deed to the earth.” The analogy captures the biblical ideas of legal authority, redemption, inheritance, and restoration.

However, Scripture never explicitly identifies the Revelation scroll as a title deed to the earth.

The phrase should therefore be treated as an interpretive description rather than a definitive identification. Jeremiah's sealed deed is one important piece of the larger biblical picture that helps illuminate the meaning of the scroll.

IV. The Scroll and the Books Written in Heaven

Before identifying the scroll in Revelation 5, we should recognize that Scripture repeatedly speaks of books or records associated with heaven. The Bible mentions the *Book of Life* (Psalm 69:28; Revelation 20:12), books in which human deeds are recorded for judgment (Daniel 7:10; Revelation 20:12), and God's book in which David's days were written before they came to pass:

“Your eyes saw me before I was formed; and all my days were written in Your book and ordained for me before one of them came to be.”

— Psalm 139:16

Daniel also speaks of a book concerning the end times that was sealed until the appointed time (Daniel 12:4, 9).

These passages do not necessarily refer to the same literal book. They do, however, establish a consistent biblical picture: *God records, knows, and sovereignly determines what concerns His people, their deeds, and the unfolding of history.*

This provides an important background for the scroll of Revelation 5. It is a heavenly document, already in the hand of God, completely sealed, and awaiting the appointed moment when the One who is worthy will open it.

The picture is of God holding in His hand the scroll in which the course and fulfillment of all things have been written. Nothing is unfolding by chance; its end is already known to God and rests in His sovereign hand. He alone holds the scroll, and He alone initiates the unfolding of His purposes until all things are brought to completion.

Only God can hold this scroll, and only the God-Man, Jesus Christ, is worthy to open it.

V. The Lamb's Worthiness Reveals the Nature of the Scroll

The identity of the One who takes the scroll provides one of the strongest clues to its meaning.

The elder tells John to look for:

“the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David”

— Revelation 5:5

But when John looks, he sees:

“a Lamb who appeared to have been slain”

— Revelation 5:6

The Lamb's worthiness is directly connected to His redemptive work. Heaven declares:

“Worthy are You to take the scroll and open its seals, because You were slain, and by Your blood You purchased for God those from every tribe and tongue and people and nation. You have made them to be a kingdom and priests to serve our God, and they will reign upon the earth.”

— Revelation 5:9–10

This is crucial to understanding the scroll.

The Lamb is worthy not merely because He possesses power or knowledge, but because He was slain and redeemed a people for God.

His taking of the scroll is immediately connected with the establishment of a kingdom and the reign of the redeemed upon the earth.

The scroll therefore cannot be reduced to a document containing judgments alone. Its significance extends to redemption, inheritance, kingdom, and the restoration of righteous rule.

VI. The Scroll Is Larger Than the Seven Seal Judgments

It is tempting to identify the scroll itself with the judgments that follow the opening of its seals. That interpretation is too narrow.

Revelation 6 and 8 describe events associated with the opening of the seven seals, but the book continues beyond the seals to the trumpets, the bowls, the judgment of Babylon, the defeat of the beast and false prophet, the final defeat of Satan, the resurrection and judgment, and ultimately the new heaven and new earth.

The seals therefore appear to initiate the unfolding of the larger divine purpose represented by the scroll rather than constituting the entire content of the scroll themselves.

Revelation never says that each seal represents a separate section of the document, nor does it state that the scroll contains seven isolated judgments.

It simply tells us that the document is sealed with seven seals and that the Lamb alone is worthy to break them.

VII. A Layered Presentation Rather Than a Strictly Linear Chronology

When we examine the seals, trumpets, and bowls in light of Christ's ultimate victory, the establishment of His millennial kingdom, and finally the new heaven and new earth, Revelation appears to present a *layered effect* rather than a strictly linear chronology.

This does not eliminate progression. The book clearly moves toward a final consummation. However, the trumpets and bowls may revisit, expand, and intensify events introduced by the seals rather than representing three entirely separate chronological periods. Later visions often provide another perspective on events already introduced, progressively adding detail and intensity as the narrative moves toward its climax.

This helps explain why similar themes and events appear more than once throughout Revelation. Rather than viewing every vision as the next event on a single chronological timeline, we can understand some passages as *recapitulating* earlier events from a different perspective. The effect is like successive layers, each revealing another dimension of God's unfolding purpose.

Thus, the visions progressively unfold the divine decree represented by the scroll, moving toward its ultimate fulfillment in Christ's victory, the establishment of His kingdom, final judgment, and ultimately the restoration of creation.

VIII. The Significance of the Seven Seals

The seven seals reinforce the completeness and security of the scroll.

Throughout Revelation, the number seven frequently conveys completeness or fullness. The document is not merely sealed once; it is sealed with seven seals.

This emphasizes that access to what God has decreed is completely restricted until the One who is worthy appears.

The emphasis of Revelation 5 is not on explaining the physical mechanics of an ancient scroll but on demonstrating the absolute authority of God and the unique worthiness of the Lamb.

The seven seals therefore emphasize that God's purposes are completely secured and cannot be opened or brought to fulfillment by anyone except Christ, who alone is worthy to break the seals and unfold what God has decreed.

IX. Why Does John Weep?

John's reaction provides another important clue.

Revelation 5:4 says:

“And I began to weep bitterly, because no one was found worthy to open the scroll or look inside it.”

John's grief seems disproportionate if the issue is merely gaining information about future events.

His reaction makes greater sense if the scroll represents the divine purpose that must be brought to completion. If no one is worthy to open it, God's promised purposes remain apparently unopened and unfulfilled.

The judgment of evil, the vindication of God's people, and the establishment of God's kingdom remain unresolved.

John is therefore told:

“Do not weep!”

— Revelation 5:5

Why?

Because:

“the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has triumphed.”

— Revelation 5:5

The answer to the problem represented by the sealed scroll is Christ Himself.

X. The Scroll and the Consummation of God's Plan

The major biblical parallels now converge.

Ezekiel connects a two-sided scroll with divine judgment. Daniel connects a sealed book with God's end-time purposes awaiting their appointed fulfillment. Jeremiah connects a sealed legal document with redemption, inheritance, and restoration.

Revelation 4 establishes God's sovereignty as Creator, while Revelation 5 presents the Lamb as the One worthy to take the scroll and open its seals.

The Lamb's victory results in the redemption of God's people and their reign upon the earth.

These themes are too broad to reduce the scroll to any single category. It is not merely a prophecy, merely a judgment document, or merely a title deed.

Rather, it represents the comprehensive divine decree concerning the consummation of God's purposes for His creation.

Those purposes include the judgment of evil, the vindication of God's people, the fulfillment of God's promises, the defeat of His enemies, the establishment of Christ's kingdom, and the ultimate restoration of creation.

XI. The Scroll and the End of Revelation

This understanding also fits the overall movement of Revelation.

Revelation 4 establishes the throne of God and His authority as Creator. Revelation 5 introduces the sealed scroll and the question of who is worthy to open it.

The Lamb takes the scroll, and the seals begin to be opened. The subsequent visions move history toward its appointed climax.

Revelation 19 presents Christ's victorious return. Revelation 20 describes the final defeat of Satan and the judgment. Revelation 21–22 brings the story to the new heaven and new earth.

The scroll therefore stands at a pivotal point in the book. It represents the divine purpose that must unfold as history moves from the present fallen order toward the final restoration of all things.

In this sense, the scroll is not merely a *book about the future*. It is the heavenly document representing what God has determined to accomplish.

Conclusion: What Is the Scroll?

Revelation does not explicitly define the scroll in a single statement. Yet its imagery, Old Testament background, and the Lamb's response provide a compelling picture of its significance.

The scroll of Revelation 5 is the sealed heavenly decree of God's sovereign purposes for the consummation of His plan for creation—the divine document associated with judgment, redemption, inheritance, and the establishment of Christ's kingdom.

Its opening sets in motion the unfolding of everything God has determined to accomplish.

The central issue, therefore, is not simply what the scroll contains, but *who is worthy to open it*. No created being is found worthy. John weeps because God's purposes appear to remain unopened and unfulfilled.

Then the Lion of Judah appears—but John sees a Lamb who has been slain.

Christ alone is worthy. His death secured redemption, His resurrection established His authority, and His triumph guarantees that God's purposes will be brought to completion.

The One who was slain is the One who will bring God's entire redemptive purpose to its appointed end. The Lamb does not merely open the scroll—He carries its purposes to their fulfillment.